

Picture Imperfect

DELHI Former President A.P.J Abdul Kalam was known for his dishevelled hair, but the country's first woman President Pratibha Patil is exactly the opposite. She is prim and proper and wants to be seen as such. So much so that the Indian missions abroad could end up celebrating India's 60th Independence Day with a blank frame of the President of India.

The reason: the photograph of the President which was clicked after much delay, approved by the Rashtrapati Bhavan and then sent to all the Indian missions abroad by the Foreign Office has been abruptly withdrawn. The message just said the photograph shouldn't be used, giving no reasons whatsoever. But according to sources, the 'flaw' that took a toll on the picture was that a part of the *pallu* of Patil's sari covered her face (see picture). When this fact



SARI TALE: The photograph which was withdrawn was brought to her notice, the photograph was recalled. Despite several attempts, there has been no official word from the Rashtrapati Bhavan on the issue. But the nixing order has led to some embarrassment.

This year being the 60th year of Independence, there are slated to be grand celebrations at Indian missions across the globe where the photographs of the

President and the prime minister will be placed next to the visitors' book and the message from the President will be read. Now all this will not look good without the President's photograph. Last heard, the official Rashtrapati Bhavan photographer had finally got the picture right and Her Excellency is

said to be sufficiently pleased. The staffers at Raisina Hill are now busy dispatching copies of the new picture to Government offices across the country and to Indian missions in distant lands. The pity is that the pictures are unlikely to reach their overseas destinations on time and perhaps for the first time ever, a photograph of the country's President will not adorn our missions abroad.

by Saurabh Shukla

SIGNPOSTS

ARRESTED: Orissa's marathon boy Budhia Singh's coach **Biranchi Das** in Bhubaneswar for allegedly torturing the child. Budhia's mother had lodged an FIR against Das accusing him of "inhuman torture".

AWARDED: The highest film honour, Dada Saheb



Phalke Award for Lifetime Achievement in cinema to filmmaker **Shyam Benegal**.

Benegal, who brought alive Nehru's *Discovery of India* for the masses, is the 37th recipient of this award.

WON: By **Mahesh Bhupathi** his 40th doubles title when he bagged the Rogers Masters Title with Czech partner Pavel Vizner. They defeated Australia's Paul Henley and Zimbabwe's Kevin Ullyett 6-4, 6-4.

CHOSEN: Trap shooter **Manavjit Singh Sandhu** for the country's highest sporting award, the Rajiv Gandhi Khel Ratna.

VIS-A-VIS JAVED AKHTAR poet-lyricist versus ASADUDDIN OWAIISI Majlis-e-Itehadul Muslimeen leader

Taslima's attackers have always criticised groups like VHP. What is the difference between them and Hindu fundamentalists?



Muslims are proud of what our legislators have done because we cannot tolerate any insult to Prophet Mohammad.

EPILOGUE: Fundamentalism is an evil every religion has to tackle—be it Hinduism, Christianity or Islam.